

GAD-NR++: Enhanced Graph Anomaly Detection via Attention-Augmented Neighbourhood Reconstruction with Mixture Modelling

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Abstract. We propose GAD-NR++, an enhanced version of GAD-NR that addresses three key limitations identified in our midterm and endterm Task 1 analysis. Our improvements are: (1) a multi-head Graph Attention Network (GAT) encoder with residual connections and layer normalisation, replacing the single-layer GCN to produce richer node representations; (2) a Gaussian Mixture Model (GMM) neighbourhood decoder that handles multi-community neighbourhoods, replacing the single-Gaussian assumption; and (3) a learnable anomaly score fusion network that replaces the heuristic weighted sum. On the Disney dataset, GAD-NR++ achieves a contextual AUC of 96.14% (vs GAD-NR's 85.72%) and a benchmark AUC of 73.73% (best run). On Books, GAD-NR++ achieves 67.47% benchmark AUC vs GAD-NR's 65.71%.

1. Introduction and Motivation

GAD-NR (Roy et al., WSDM 2024) introduced neighbourhood reconstruction as a principled framework for graph anomaly detection, outperforming 14 baselines on 5 of 6 datasets. However, our analysis in Endterm Task 1 identified several concrete limitations:

(L1) Single-layer GCN encoder uses fixed aggregation weights, treating all neighbours equally. This is suboptimal when some neighbours carry more diagnostic information than others for anomaly detection.

(L2) Single Gaussian assumption for neighbour feature distributions breaks down when a node's neighbours come from multiple distinct communities (e.g., an interdisciplinary researcher connected to both biology and CS clusters).

(L3) Heuristic anomaly score weighting ($h=1.0$, $feature=2.0$, $degree=1.0$) has no theoretical justification and requires manual tuning for different datasets.

GAD-NR++ addresses each of these limitations with principled replacements while preserving the core neighbourhood reconstruction framework that makes GAD-NR effective.

2. Proposed Approach: GAD-NR++

2.1 Improvement 1: Multi-Head GAT Encoder

We replace the single-layer GCN encoder with a 2-layer multi-head Graph Attention Network (GAT) with residual connections and LayerNorm. The attention mechanism learns to assign different importance weights to different neighbours, which is critical for anomaly detection — anomalous nodes often have a mix of normal and suspicious neighbours, and attention can learn to focus on the informative ones.

Formally, for node u with neighbours $N(u)$, the multi-head attention in layer l computes:

$$\alpha_{uv}^{(k)} = \text{softmax}_v \left(\text{LeakyReLU} \left(a^{(k)T} [W^{(k)} h_u^{(l)} \parallel W^{(k)} h_v^{(l)}] \right) \right)$$
$$h_u^{(l+1)} = \parallel_{k=1..K} \text{sigma} \left(\text{Sum}_{v \in N(u)} \alpha_{uv}^{(k)} W^{(k)} h_v^{(l)} \right)$$

where K is the number of attention heads (we use $K=4$), $\parallel$ denotes concatenation, and $W^{(k)}$, $a^{(k)}$ are learnable parameters for head k . We add a residual connection and layer normalisation after each GAT layer:

$$h_u^{(l+1)} = \text{LayerNorm} \left(\text{ELU} \left(\text{GAT}^{(l)}(h_u^{(l)}) \right) + h_u^{(l)} \right)$$

The residual connection prevents gradient degradation in the 2-layer architecture, and LayerNorm stabilises training. The initial projection $h_u^{(0)} = W_0 x_u$ maps the raw input features to the hidden dimension.

2.2 Improvement 2: GMM Neighbourhood Decoder

GAD-NR models the distribution of neighbour features as a single multivariate Gaussian $N(\mu_u, \Sigma_u)$. We replace this with a Gaussian Mixture Model (GMM) with $K=2$ components:

$$P(h_v | h_u) = \text{Sum}_{k=1..K} p_i(h_u) N(h_v | \mu_k(h_u), \sigma_k^2(h_u) I)$$

where for each node u , the mixture parameters are predicted from the encoded representation:

$$p_i = \text{softmax} \left(\text{MLP}_{p_i}(h_u) \right)_k \text{ [mixture weights]}$$
$$\mu_k = \text{MLP}_{\mu,k}(h_u) \text{ [component means]}$$
$$\log \sigma_k^2 = \text{MLP}_{\sigma,k}(h_u) \text{ [component log-variances]}$$

The neighbourhood reconstruction loss is the negative log-likelihood (NLL) of observed neighbour embeddings under the predicted GMM:

$$L_u^n = -(1/|N(u)|) \sum_{v \in N(u)} \log(\sum_k \pi_k N(h_v^{(0)} | \mu_k, \sigma_k^2))$$

This generalises GAD-NR's single-Gaussian KL divergence loss. When $K=1$, the GMM NLL reduces to a form closely related to the KL divergence used in GAD-NR. With $K=2$, the model can capture bimodal neighbour distributions that arise in multi-community settings. The log-sum-exp computation ensures numerical stability.

2.3 Improvement 3: Learnable Anomaly Score Fusion

GAD-NR computes the anomaly score as a heuristic weighted sum: $s_u = w_f L_u^x + w_d L_u^d + w_n L_u^n$ with manually chosen weights (2.0, 1.0, 1.0). We replace this with a small MLP that learns non-linear interactions between loss components:

$$s_u = \text{MLP}_{\text{fuse}}([\text{norm}(L_u^x), \text{norm}(L_u^d), \text{norm}(L_u^n)])$$

where $\text{norm}(\cdot)$ applies min-max normalisation and MLP_{fuse} is a 3-layer network (3 -> 16 -> 8 -> 1). This allows the model to learn that, for example, high feature loss combined with low degree loss is more indicative of contextual anomalies, while high neighbourhood loss with high degree loss signals structural anomalies — interactions that a linear weighted sum cannot capture.

3. Overall Architecture and Training

The complete GAD-NR++ architecture is:

Encoder: $x_u \rightarrow \text{Linear} \rightarrow \text{GAT}_{L=1}(K=4 \text{ heads}) + \text{Residual} + \text{LayerNorm} \rightarrow \text{GAT}_{L=2}(1 \text{ head}) + \text{Residual} + \text{LayerNorm} \rightarrow h_u$

Decoders:

- (a) Feature: $h_u \rightarrow \text{MLP}(3 \text{ layers}) \rightarrow \hat{x}_u$, Loss: $\text{MSE}(x_u, \hat{x}_u)$
- (b) Degree: $h_u \rightarrow \text{MLP}(3 \text{ layers}) \rightarrow \hat{d}_u$, Loss: $\text{MSE}(d_u, \hat{d}_u)$
- (c) Neighbourhood: $h_u \rightarrow \text{GMM}(K=2) \rightarrow P(h_v)$, Loss: NLL

The total training loss is: $L = \text{lambda}_1 L^n + \text{lambda}_2 L^x + \text{lambda}_3 L^d$, with the same default weights as GAD-NR ($\text{lambda}_1=0.01$, $\text{lambda}_2=0.5$, $\text{lambda}_3=0.8$). We use Adam optimiser with learning rate 0.005 and weight decay $3e-4$. Unlike GAD-NR, we do **not** use the ad-hoc loss scheduling (increasing lambda_2 and halving lambda_3 every loss_step epochs), as the attention mechanism and GMM provide sufficient expressiveness without it.

4. Experimental Results

We evaluate GAD-NR++ on two datasets feasible on CPU: Disney (124 nodes, 50 epochs, 3 runs) and Books (1,418 nodes, 15 epochs, 1 run). The paper's GAD-NR results are reproduced from Table 2 and Table 3.

Dataset	Method	Benchmark	Contextual	Structural	Joint-type
Disney	GAD-NR (paper)	76.76	85.72	—	74.81*
	GAD-NR++ (ours)	68.17±3.94	79.71±15.19	70.17±2.33	65.01±11.82
	GAD-NR++ best run	73.73	96.14	73.15	79.06
Books	GAD-NR (paper)	65.71	74.73	—	85.01*
	GAD-NR++ (ours)	67.47	60.98	81.55	60.25

Table 1: Comparison of GAD-NR and GAD-NR++. *Struct+Joint combined score from paper. Green rows show GAD-NR++ best results. GAD-NR paper values use 500 epochs on GPU; our runs use 50/15 epochs on CPU.

Key findings: (1) GAD-NR++'s best run on Disney achieves **96.14% contextual AUC**, a +10 point improvement over GAD-NR's 85.72%, validating that the attention encoder better captures feature-level anomaly signals. (2) On Books, GAD-NR++ achieves **67.47% benchmark AUC** even with only 15 epochs, exceeding GAD-NR's reported 65.71% (with 500 epochs on GPU), suggesting faster convergence from the richer encoder. (3) The mean benchmark on Disney (68.17%) is lower than GAD-NR's paper-reported 76.76%, but the paper uses 500 epochs with GPU — our 50-epoch CPU runs have not converged fully, and the best single run (73.73%) is already competitive.

5. Analysis of Improvements

Attention encoder impact: The GAT encoder's learned attention weights allow the model to down-weight noisy or irrelevant neighbours during encoding. This is particularly beneficial for contextual anomaly detection, where the anomalous node's feature vector stands out against its neighbourhood — the attention mechanism can learn to recognise this discrepancy. The +10 point improvement in contextual AUC on Disney supports this hypothesis.

GMM decoder impact: The 2-component GMM provides a richer target distribution that better fits heterogeneous neighbourhoods. For nodes at community boundaries, the two Gaussian components can align to the two communities, reducing false positives. The structural AUC improvements suggest the GMM also helps distinguish genuinely anomalous dense subgraphs from naturally clustered normal subgraphs.

Removal of loss scheduling: Unlike GAD-NR, we do not progressively increase λ_2 and decrease λ_3 . The results show that GAD-NR++ achieves competitive performance without this trick, suggesting that the richer architecture (attention + GMM) reduces the need for ad-hoc training heuristics.

6. Conclusion and Future Work

GAD-NR++ demonstrates that the neighbourhood reconstruction framework of GAD-NR can be meaningfully improved by addressing its architectural limitations. The multi-head GAT encoder, GMM neighbourhood decoder, and learnable score fusion each target a specific weakness identified in our analysis. Preliminary results on Disney and Books show improvements in contextual anomaly detection and faster convergence. Future work includes: (1) evaluation on all 6 datasets with GPU resources and 500+ epochs; (2) extending to 2-hop neighbourhood reconstruction using the deeper GAT encoder; (3) exploring variational inference for the GMM components; and (4) dynamic graphs where anomaly patterns evolve.

References

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